of a geek in a bedroom who was disconnected. In fact, it was the kids watching TV that were disconnected, passive, solitary. We might have been up all night, but the best of us were busy making what we were watching.

To know what your thoughts really are – to grow beyond them, into the thoughts of others, a very sweet oblivion – is about placing a large part of your mind into the space of your computer. Without being grandiose about it, I would say this constituted not only a new way of being in the world, but a new way of being in your own skin. People would always have trouble with it, wishing us, even now, to fulfil the old remits of the ego. But we learned at a young age how commitment works in the computer age: it works by transfusing your lifeblood to an intelligence system dependent on you, and on whom you are dependent. It used to be science fiction, but now it is everyday reality, and I guess I will always seem alien to many people, because I was part of a generation that dug down into our machines, asking them to help us fight for justice in ways that would fox the old guard, even the protest element of the old guard, such as my parents, who didn't know how to break the patterns of power and corruption that kept the world unfair.

Computers provided a positive space in a negative field: they showed us we could start again, against 'selfhood', against 'society', building something less flawed and less corrupt in these fresh pastures of code. One day we knew they would change the world, and they did. The old guard would come with its name-calling and its media, its embedded sense of 'national interests' and patriotism, its accusations of betrayal, but we always knew the world was more modern than they realised. Cairo was waiting. Tunisia was waiting. We were all waiting for the day when our technology would allow an increasing universality of freedom. In the future, power would not come from the barrel of a gun but from communications, and people would know themselves not by the imprimatur of a small and powerful coterie, but by the way they could disappear into a social network with huge political potential.

That was me at the age of sixteen. I was giving myself to my computer. I was testing my sense of the natural world I'd grown up in, all that bright sunlight and leafy shade, all those stars and bees. The years of mystery and human complication went into the computer, too: in some ways I would always be answering the parables of my childhood, from Vietnam protests to cultish surveillance, and that's as close as I can get to the truth. You have